frequently criticized for its inflexibility and has been slow to address violations of rule-of-law norms because of its reliance on unanimous consent. For instance, Hungary's Viktor Orbán has repeatedly used procedural delays and veto power to evade EU sanctions under Article 7. These delays allow populist leaders to enact controversial policies while IOs remain entangled in bureaucratic processes, effectively neutralizing potential consequences.

By contrast, IOs with adaptable governance models, such as those led by centralized secretariats or flexible voting arrangements, are better positioned to withstand populist pressures. These organizations can make decisions more quickly, minimizing the window of opportunity for populists to undermine collective action. As IOs face an evolving landscape of challenges, re-examining their decision-making rules to enhance agility and responsiveness may be key to ensuring their continued resilience and relevance in a world increasingly shaped by populist politics.

9.3 Normative Implications

The strategies IOs use to defend themselves against populist threats often create significant ripple effects, shaping their operations and structures long after an immediate challenge has passed. These downstream consequences vary in magnitude depending on whether the chosen response involves minor adjustments or sweeping reforms. IOs can adapt more flexibly if their actions are reversible, such as launching people-focused social media campaigns or temporarily relaxing loan conditions for populist-led states. These adjustments can be undone without much difficulty once the political climate shifts.

In contrast, structural reforms that reconfigure power dynamics or alter institutional frameworks tend to have enduring impacts. These changes often become deeply entrenched as a result of institutional inertia and the tendency to maintain the status quo. For instance, creating secret channels for engagement or granting populist states substantial influence within an IO can fundamentally reshape the organization. Even when nonpopulist leaders return to power, they may have limited leverage or fear political backlash if they attempt to undo these changes. A case in point is the Biden administration's decision not to restore the WTO Appellate Body, which